THE INDUS VALLEY

CIVILIZATION

A chapter for Classes 6–8

History • Cities • People • Trade • Change

Chapter question: How did people build and sustain one of the world's earliest urban civilizations?

In this chapter, you will learn about the beginnings of Harappan society, its cities and water systems, farming, crafts,

trade, beliefs, and the changes that took place after its urban peak.

Learning goals

• Locate the civilization's broad region and place its main phases on a timeline.

• Describe town planning, drainage, water storage, farming, crafts and trade.

• Identify important archaeological sites and what they reveal.

• Separate archaeological evidence from ideas that remain uncertain.

Student-friendly learning resource • Written in original wording • NCERT-style overview

1. What was the Indus Valley Civilization?

The Indus Valley Civilization, also called the Harappan Civilization, was one of the world's earliest urban

civilizations. It developed in parts of present-day Pakistan and north-western and western India. It is especially

known for planned settlements, baked-brick buildings, drainage systems, craft production, standardized weights and

long-distance trade.

The name "Harappan Civilization" comes from Harappa, one of the first major sites excavated. The term "Indus

Valley Civilization" is also widely used, although the civilization spread far beyond the Indus River valley.

Archaeologists study objects and structures left behind—such as bricks, pottery, tools, seals, bones, wells and

drains—to learn about the past. Since the Harappan script has not been conclusively deciphered, many details

about its government, language and religious beliefs remain uncertain.

2. When did it flourish?

Phase Approximate dates Main features

Early farming communitiesBefore c. 3300 BCE Farming and herding developed in the wider region. Mehrgarh is an important earlier settlement.

Early Harappan c. 3300–2600 BCE Towns and villages grew; regional exchange and craft traditions expanded.

Mature Harappan c. 2600–1900 BCE Large planned cities, extensive trade, seals and standardized objects were widespread.

Late Harappan c. 1900–1300 BCE Many major cities changed or became smaller; settlement patterns shifted.

Dates are approximate and can vary by site. The transformation of Harappan urban life was gradual and differed

across the region.

3. Geography and environment

Harappan settlements occupied a wide and varied landscape, including river plains, semi-arid areas and coastal

regions. Rivers provided water, fertile soil and routes for travel. Coastal locations helped connect some communities

to maritime trade.

• **Indus River and tributaries:** supported settlement across a broad region.

• **Ghaggar-Hakra region:** many Harappan sites occur around this river system and nearby channels; the ancient

river courses are still studied.

• **Coastal settlements:** helped communities participate in exchange across the Arabian Sea.

• **Changing climate and rivers:** changes in rainfall and water availability may have affected farming and settlement

over time.

Remember: the civilization's distribution was much wider than the modern Indus River basin. Maps may differ

because ancient river courses and settlement boundaries are still being researched.

4. Discovery and excavation

Ancient mounds were known locally before modern archaeological excavations. Work in the early twentieth century

revealed that Harappa and Mohenjo-daro belonged to a major ancient civilization.

• **Daya Ram Sahni** led excavations at Harappa in 1921.

• **R. D. Banerji** began excavations at Mohenjo-daro in 1922.

• **John Marshall**, then Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India, announced the discovery of the

civilization in 1924.

• Later surveys and excavations found many more sites in India and Pakistan.

Archaeology continues today. New scientific methods and discoveries can change earlier interpretations.

5. Important sites

Site Present-day location What it is known for

Harappa Punjab, Pakistan A key excavated site that gave the civilization its alternative name.

Mohenjo-daro Sindh, Pakistan The Great Bath, planned streets, brick buildings and drainage.

Dholavira Gujarat, India Reservoirs, water management and carefully organized city areas.

Rakhigarhi Haryana, India One of the largest known Harappan settlement areas.

Lothal Gujarat, India Bead-making and maritime connections; a basin often interpreted as a dockyard.

Kalibangan Rajasthan, India Evidence of a ploughed field and fire installations.

Mehrgarh Balochistan, Pakistan An earlier farming settlement that helps explain the long background to urban life.

A settlement's importance depends on its evidence. Not every Harappan settlement was a large city, and different

places had different roles.

6. Town planning and buildings

Many Mature Harappan towns show careful planning. Streets, houses, drains and public structures reveal shared

building practices and practical engineering knowledge.

• **Streets:** in several cities, streets and lanes followed planned layouts, though not every city was identical.

• **Bricks:** people used mud bricks and baked bricks; some followed standardized proportions.

• **Houses:** layouts varied. Some homes had courtyards, bathing spaces, wells or access to drains.

• **City areas:** archaeologists often identify raised or strongly built areas and lower residential areas, but

arrangements differed by site.

• **Public structures:** the Great Bath at Mohenjo-daro and water structures at Dholavira are especially notable.

Similar building practices suggest connections and organization. However, archaeologists have not established

that every city was controlled by one king or a single empire.

7. Drainage and water management

Water was essential to city life. Wells, bathing spaces, drains and reservoirs show that many Harappan communities

invested in collecting, using and directing water.

• Some cities contained many wells, so residents could obtain water in their neighbourhoods.

• Household bathing areas and drains carried wastewater away from buildings.

• Some street drains were covered and designed so they could be accessed for cleaning.

• Dholavira had reservoirs and channels for collecting and storing water in a relatively dry environment.

Why this matters: reliable water supply and drainage help communities support larger populations and keep living

areas cleaner.

8. Agriculture, animals and food

Farming supported Harappan settlements. Communities grew crops, raised animals and used the resources

available in their local environments.

• **Crops:** wheat, barley, pulses, sesame, mustard and cotton are among the crops associated with Harappan

communities. Evidence for rice occurs at some sites, but its importance varied.

• **Animals:** cattle, sheep, goats and water buffalo were important to many communities.

• **Farming evidence:** tools, plant remains and a possible ploughed field at Kalibangan help archaeologists study

cultivation.

• **Food and storage:** grains, pulses and other local foods supported daily life; stored food could help supply people

in larger settlements.

Cotton is notable in the history of textiles in the region. Actual ancient cloth rarely survives, so evidence is often

indirect.

9. Crafts and technology

Harappan craftspeople made useful tools and decorative objects. Their work required knowledge of materials,

heating, shaping, drilling and polishing.

Craft Examples

Pottery Bowls, jars, cooking vessels and painted designs.

Bead-making Beads of carnelian, agate, shell, faience and other materials.

Metalworking Copper and bronze tools and objects, as well as gold and silver ornaments.

Shell working Bangles, inlays and ornaments.

Seals Small carved objects with animal motifs and short inscriptions.

Weights Carefully made weights suggesting shared standards for measuring goods.

Terracotta Figurines, toys, carts and other objects; their uses are not always certain.

Two famous finds from Mohenjo-daro are a bronze figurine popularly called the “Dancing Girl” and a stone bust

often called the “Priest-King.” These are modern labels; the figures’ actual roles are not known.

10. Seals and the Indus script

Many Harappan seals show animals and short sequences of signs. Similar signs also appear on other objects.

Researchers call this writing system the Indus script, but it has not been conclusively deciphered.

• Most inscriptions are short.

• Animal images may have had symbolic, social, commercial or other meanings.

• Some scholars suggest seals helped identify people or goods, but their exact uses remain debated.

• Because the script is undeciphered, it is difficult to identify rulers, laws, stories or beliefs directly from written

records.

Be careful with claims that the script has been definitively decoded. There is no widely accepted decipherment.

11. Trade and the economy

Harappan communities exchanged goods locally and with distant regions. River routes, overland paths and coastal

travel helped move raw materials and finished products.

• **Local exchange:** food, pottery, tools and ornaments moved between communities.

• **Long-distance links:** connections extended to regions of present-day Afghanistan, Iran, Oman and Mesopotamia.

• **Materials:** copper, shell, timber and semi-precious stones came from different regions.

• **Craft goods:** beads, ornaments, textiles and other products may have travelled through trade networks.

• **Weights and seals:** these may have helped with measuring, identifying or managing goods, although exact

functions are not certain.

Mesopotamian texts mention a place called “Meluhha,” which many scholars associate with the Indus region. The

precise nature of all trade connections remains under study.

12. Daily life, art and beliefs

Daily life

People lived in houses of different sizes and worked as farmers, craftspeople, traders and other specialists. Beads,

bangles and necklaces were made from stone, shell, metal and baked clay. Models and other finds offer clues about

carts, boats, play and transport.

Art

Seals, pottery, figurines and jewellery show a wide range of artistic skills. These objects also provide evidence about

technology, exchange and personal adornment.

Beliefs and burial practices

Beliefs are difficult to reconstruct because the script is undeciphered. Some figurines and seals have been

interpreted as religious images, but many interpretations are debated. The Great Bath may have been used for ritual

bathing or another communal purpose, but its exact function is not proven. Burial practices also varied.

A useful historical habit is to separate what archaeologists found from what they think it might mean.

13. Why did the urban centres change?

After about 1900 BCE, many major urban centres became smaller or were used differently. The process was

gradual and varied across the region; historians do not identify one explanation that accounts for every settlement.

• **Climate and rainfall:** changing monsoon patterns may have affected farming in some areas.

• **River changes:** shifts in river courses and water availability may have influenced settlement.

• **Trade changes:** long-distance exchange networks changed over time.

• **Movement and adaptation:** people may have moved to places with more dependable resources.

• **Regional differences:** some cities declined while smaller settlements and regional cultures continued.

It is inaccurate to say that the entire civilization suddenly disappeared in one event. People continued living in the

region, and settlement patterns and cultural practices changed over time.

14. The legacy of the Harappan Civilization

• It shows early urban planning and large-scale construction in South Asia.

• Its wells, drains and reservoirs reveal practical water-management skills.

• Standardized weights and craft production point to complex economic networks.

• Seals, pottery, ornaments and figurines preserve evidence of artistic ability.

• Its sites help researchers understand how people responded to changing environments and trade.

• It remains an important subject of archaeological research.

15. Quick revision

Key facts to remember

Question Answer

What are the two common names? Indus Valley Civilization and Harappan Civilization.

When was the Mature Harappan phase? Approximately 2600–1900 BCE.

Who excavated Harappa in 1921? Daya Ram Sahni.

Which site is famous for the Great Bath? Mohenjo-daro.

Which site is famous for reservoirs? Dholavira.

Which crop is especially important in early textile history? Cotton.

Has the Indus script been conclusively deciphered? No.

Was the urban transformation sudden everywhere? No; it was gradual and varied by region.

Practice questions

• Describe three features of Harappan town planning.

• How did wells, drains and reservoirs support city life?

• Name four important sites and state what each reveals.

• Explain how farming, crafts and trade supported the civilization.

• Why must historians be careful when discussing Harappan religion and writing?

• Give two possible factors behind the transformation of major urban centres after about 1900 BCE.

Chapter summary

The Indus Valley or Harappan Civilization developed across a broad region of South Asia. Its mature urban phase,

about 2600–1900 BCE, is known for planned settlements, water management, farming, skilled crafts, standardized

weights and long-distance trade. Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Lothal, Kalibangan and Rakhigarhi provide

important evidence. The Indus script remains undeciphered, so some aspects of society and belief are uncertain.

After about 1900 BCE, many urban centres changed gradually as environmental, economic and social conditions

shifted.

Further learning: consult NCERT history textbooks, Archaeological Survey of India resources, museum collections and UNESCO material

on relevant archaeological sites. This is an original student-friendly overview, not a reproduction of an NCERT textbook.